

Episode 115: It's February Already But... New Year Special Edition – *Strong World ONE PIECE FILM*Notes (Final Part 1)

Somehow, it's become February already!

February.

The cold suddenly got severe, and Tokyo suddenly had snow falling...

Plus I hear talk about the winter Olympics coming up soon, but this February, as someone handling programmes starting in April, every day is nothing but pressure.

Because February is short! Two whole days shorter than regular months!

If I can skillfully conquer this February, I'm sure I can greet March and then April with a smile. Believing that, I'm working hard every day.

Yeah, do your best > Japan. And, do your best > Me

Please look forward to that new programmes *The Tatami Galaxy*!

Now then.

Strong World's original deadline was actually mid-September. The plan from the publicity department and production committee was to deliver three months before the nationwide December 12th release, then spend three months on promotion, but delays starting with the storyboard completion delay gradually widened that wound, and particularly the delays in animation—layout animation completion and its checking work—became the biggest cause of delays for all subsequent departments.

(Oh right, one big numerical error in the previous instalment. The total cut count wasn't "over 1400" but about 2200 cuts. Hahaha! (laugh) I'd noticed I wrote it wrong but missed it in final checking and sent it to the editorial department as-is. Incidentally, this cut count equals about seven TV episodes. It was the largest cut count in my career!)

Without layout approval, neither key animation work nor art background work can proceed. We assigned multiple assistant animation directors and tackled correction work on the massive number of cuts, but progress was frustratingly slow. "First and foremost, properly establish animation and screen layouts to build the screen"—that was the primary important point for the director and animation team on this movie. So they ended up spending slightly more time than necessary.

So the crucial art boards were also scheduled to be drawn scene by scene waiting for actual layouts, which led to an emergency situation where even boards weren't coming up. That was the September situation.

However, you can't just sit idle saying "cuts aren't coming" or "key animation isn't coming." Even doing nothing, remaining time keeps disappearing day by day. So anyway, we start with whatever we can work on, and whatever form it takes, cuts should eventually rush in like a tsunami at the end, so we prepare to handle such situations—that's what we could do.

The rough colour design plan was mostly complete by mid-August, and after that we'd wait for art boards to be completed in sequence to create actual "colours." Between places we'd decided for the trailer, scenes where boards came up relatively early, or scenes where we'd requested boards for CG-related advance work, little by little we had a fair number of scenes with completed decisions.

While animation was certainly delayed, regarding animation work after key animation completion—in-between animation and finishing work—thanks to the "short-term overseas in-between and finishing system" built up over many years, considerable acceleration was possible. Once key animation was completed, passed the animation

director, had colour direction applied, and was ordered for in-between and finishing work, cuts would be painted through in-between animation + painting work in just 2-3 days (even "12-hour in-between and finishing" as a final measure).

But backgrounds apparently couldn't work like this. While background work also often relies on overseas for actual work, opposite to key animation where animation directors work on it before ordering, the workflow for backgrounds has art directors thoroughly work and check with their brushes after ordering and initial completion. So time reduction is difficult and it does take time.

Due to such factors and others, many scenes ended up waiting for art boards and backgrounds. With a total volume of over 2000 cuts, even with animation delays, a decent number of key animation cuts came to colour direction daily. Ideally we'd finish properly deciding each scene's "colours" before applying correct colour direction and ordering in-between and finishing work, but since moving cuts were absolutely necessary for sound work, we couldn't wait for art boards and colour decisions.

So we temporarily applied "normal" colour direction and ordered in-between and finishing work, had them painted in temporary colours, shot them as-is for now to create moving material for sound work. Behind that, we'd decide the "correct colours" for those scenes and ask retake processing painting staff to replace colours with "correct colours," then reshoot—that workflow was established. This happened for quite a lot of scenes. Especially the latter half had considerable numbers of cuts processed this way. Ah, at times like this I really think "Thank goodness for digital painting!" In the old cel era, such methods would have been absolutely impossible.

My and Kobiki-san's "colour team" was steadily building up work even in such circumstances.

As I wrote last time, work-wise, I'd first do overall colour design for the main feature, and I'd do all colour direction alone. I asked Kobiki-san to mainly handle somewhat time-consuming detailed tasks.

"Somewhat time-consuming detailed tasks"—one of these was organising mob scenes.

This work has an incredible number of pirates. Kobiki-san generally created colours for these pirates. First was creating colour direction data for pirates appearing across multiple cuts. Based on pirate reference designs from Sato-san, she created colours for the pirate captains seated in the great hall during the "raid" scene, and used that data as colour direction reference for finishing staff painting.

Then colour matching in actual painted cuts. Only a tiny handful of pirate characters were roughly established as designs, and pirates actually appearing in cuts were mostly things drawn by key animators handling those scenes & cuts as a series. She corrected and unified these painted results without inconsistencies. Plus drinks and food in taverns, swarms of pirate ships, and so on. She handled "difficult cut" after "difficult cut." That big pirate brawl during the "raid" scene—all those mob scenes—that's all Kobiki-san's work.

Incidentally, painted completion inspection involved cuts painted overseas first getting rough inspection from teams at Toei Animation mainly handling retake processing, checking for animation mistakes and missing masks. Then Kobiki-san and I would inspect all cuts once more together.

So through "sorting" at that point, I'd ask Kobiki-san to handle cuts needing cross-cut matching, cuts needing colour corrections, cuts where I'd been thinking about adding processing during colour direction, and she'd handle detailed processing work along with inspection. When I'd say "Make this 'on fire!'" to Kobiki-san, she'd make it nicely 'on fire'—that kind of combination.

"Because you're touching actual key animation and in-between animation for colour direction, you can pay attention to detailed acting and nuances"—this is my theory about colour direction work. So my usual style is to inspect painted results of cuts I did colour

direction for myself and add "one more spoonful." But in tight schedule situations like this, it often becomes difficult to do such detailed "seasoning."

But thanks to Kobiki-san participating this time, she thoroughly covered parts I couldn't have handled alone and created several cuts beyond that.

Now then now then.

We weathered crisis-filled September and plunged into October. The month from here probably became the biggest "festival" in recent years. A dialogue between Oda-san and Mr. Children's Sakurai-san was scheduled for the first week of November. That meant we absolutely had to show them completed footage before that dialogue. Which meant completion by then...!

Aaagh! (waterfall sweat)

From here on there are too many things that would cause problems for various parties to write about properly (wry laugh). Actually, during this one month, nearly 70% of the main feature's cuts flew around East Asia, and we somehow managed to reach completion.

Literally whipping young staff into shape, sometimes raising our voices, somehow keeping the director motivated while running to the finish! Those days continued. A month that passed in a flash. I spent half of it sleeping in a sleeping bag in my studio room. Before I knew it, I'd become almost the oldest person on site, so there was also a month of fighting pressure, thinking that old guy had better work hard and set an example.

And so, we utterly exhausted staff welcomed November...

(10.02.08)